

Reineke-RAG

User Handbook

Reineke-RAG — 2026

Reineke-RAG — User Handbook

This handbook is for **you, the person who will use Reineke-RAG**: logging in, asking questions about your company's documents, reading cited answers, and — if your role permits — uploading documents.

You do **not** need technical knowledge. This is a user guide. If you're an administrator looking for installation, backup, or tuning, read [TECHNICAL_HANDBOOK.md](#) instead.

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1. What Reineke-RAG is — in one minute

Reineke-RAG is your **company's internal assistant for documents**.

You type a question. It reads the Word, PDF, and Excel files you have permission to see, finds the parts that answer you, and writes a reply — in German or English — with **clickable sources** so you can verify every claim.

It runs entirely on company hardware. **Nothing leaves the building.**

Think of it as "a colleague who has read every file you can read, and will always cite where they found something."

2. What it does and doesn't do

It does

- Answer questions about your company's internal PDF / Word / Excel files.
- Understand German **and** English — ask in whichever feels natural.
- Show you the **source** for every claim (file name, page, a preview, a link to open the file).
- Handle spreadsheets numerically — "*which project in 2024 had the highest margin?*" produces a real answer computed from the data, not a guess.
- Respect your access rights. You only see and search the folders your group is allowed on.

It does not

- Browse the internet. No Wikipedia, no news, no web search. Only your files.
- Write or send emails, edit calendars, or touch any other system. It is read-only.
- Modify your documents. It reads them; the originals are never changed.
- Invent. If no accessible document contains the answer, it will say so explicitly rather than guess.
- Remember you across conversations by default — each chat starts fresh unless you're in the same conversation.

If your expectation falls outside these lines

Ask your administrator. It is likely either:

- **A planned feature** that isn't in the current version.
- **A configuration choice** your admin can change for you.
- **Intentionally off** for safety (e.g. chat file attachments, which would bypass folder permissions).

3. Logging in the first time

1. Open the URL your administrator shared. It usually looks like `https://rag.<your-company>.local`.
2. You'll be redirected to the company **single sign-on** page (branded "Authentik"). Use your normal company credentials.
3. On first login, you'll be asked to **change your password**. You may also be asked to enrol a **second factor** (authenticator app) — do it; it only takes a minute.
4. After login you land in the chat screen.

Certificate warning on first visit?

On a freshly installed system, your browser may warn about the site certificate. This is because the system uses a **company-internal certificate authority**. Your admin will either:

- Distribute the CA certificate to your computer (after which the warning goes away), **or**
- Tell you it is safe to bypass once (only on your work machine, never on public Wi-Fi).

If you see this warning on a phone or home machine, **do not bypass it**. Ask your admin.

4. A tour of the screen

Simplified sketch:

Reineke-RAG		[DE EN]	[You ▼]
Conversations + New Today · Lieferfristen Yesterday · Prozesshandbuch	assistant: ...		
	[1] DIN-18065.pdf · p. 3 [2] Angebot-2024-09.docx · §2.1		
		► Type your question... ↵	

Elements

- **Conversation list (left)** — your past chats. Your conversations are **private to your account**; administrators see audit metadata (who asked what, when), not the chat transcript.
- **+ New** — start a fresh conversation with no memory of earlier ones. Use this when you change topic.
- **Language toggle (top right, DE | EN)** — switches the system messages. The system will still answer in whatever language you ask in; the toggle mainly affects refusal messages and a few UI strings.
- **Citations ([1], [2], ...)** — little brackets inside the answer. Click one to open a preview with the file name, page, and a short excerpt. Click again to open the full file.
- **Input box (bottom)** — type your question; press ↵ to send. Streaming: the answer appears word by word as the system generates it.

What you don't see (on purpose)

- A model selector. The system picks the right language model automatically based on your question type. You don't need to choose.
 - A chat file-upload button. Uploads go through a separate, permission-aware route (see §9).
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5. Asking good questions

Reineke-RAG is smart, but your question still matters. These patterns consistently produce better answers.

5.1 Four kinds of question, each with a good pattern

Kind	Good pattern	German example	English example
Lookup (short, specific)	Name the topic with precise terms	"Welche Norm gilt für Typ-B-Schränke?"	"Which standard applies to type-B cabinets?"
Extraction (pull a list from one file)	"Liste / Extrahiere alle X aus Y"	"Liste alle Lieferfristen aus Angebot-2024-09.pdf."	"Extract all delivery deadlines from Offer-2024-09.pdf."
Table / numeric (computation)	Name the file + what to compute	"Welches Projekt in Projekte2024.xlsx hatte die höchste Marge?"	"In Projects2024.xlsx, which project had the highest margin?"
Synthesis (across many files)	"Fasse zusammen / Vergleiche ..."	"Fasse unsere Position zu Thema X über alle QMS-Dokumente zusammen."	"Summarise our position on topic X across all QMS documents."

5.2 Tricks that really help

- **Name the file** if you know it. It's a cheat code — retrieval locks onto it immediately.
- **Name the folder** if you remember only roughly where it came from ("in unseren QMS-Dokumenten...").
- **Use proper names and part numbers verbatim.** The system has keyword search built in; KR-4711-B is better than "the 4711 part".
- **Prefer one question per message.** For tricky topics, ask one thing, then follow up.
- **For numbers, ask for the calculation explicitly** — "highest", "sum", "average where X > 10". The system will write a small database query behind the scenes.

5.3 Patterns to avoid

- "What do you think about..." — it won't. It reports what documents say, not opinions.
- "Tell me everything about..." — too broad; you'll get a noisy mix. Narrow it.
- "Search the web for..." — no internet access, by design.
- "Summarise the last five PDFs uploaded" — the system doesn't have a sort-by-date concept for casual queries. Ask your admin if you need bulk operations.

5.4 Switching language

The system understands both DE and EN. If you want the **answer** in a specific language, just say so:

- "Antworte auf Deutsch."
- "Answer in English."

Or use the DE | EN toggle at the top right.

6. Reading an answer (citations matter)

Every factual claim in the answer *should* end with a bracketed number like **[1]** or **[2]**. These are **clickable citations**.

Example:

"Die Norm DIN 18065 regelt die Abmessungen [1]. Der Mindestwert beträgt 800 mm [2]."

[1] and [2] are independently clickable. Clicking shows:

- The file name.
- The page or section.
- A ~240-character preview of the exact passage.
- A link to open the full file (respecting your permissions).

Rules of thumb for reading answers

- **No citation on a claim = treat it as weak.** Sometimes the system places a citation at the end of a paragraph instead of on every sentence. Click to verify if the claim matters.
- **If the cited preview does not actually support the claim, the answer is wrong.** This is rare, but it happens. Tell your administrator — they have tools to reconstruct the query and improve the system.
- **"I didn't find information on that..." is a feature,** not a bug. It means nothing in the documents you can access supports an answer. Trust it. Do not try to "prompt around" the refusal.

On language

The answer language usually matches your question. If it mismatches (you asked in German, got English), just append "Antworte auf Deutsch." — or toggle DE | EN.

On length

The system chooses length based on the kind of question:

- Lookup → short, direct.
- Extraction → structured, often a list.
- Table-math → concise answer + (optionally) the SQL query used.
- Synthesis → longer, multi-paragraph.

You can always ask for more: "*Ausführlicher bitte.*" / "*Give me more detail.*"

7. Special cases: tables and numbers

When you ask about a **spreadsheet** or a **number**, the system does something different:

- It writes a small **SQL query** against the data.
- It runs that query (safely — you cannot run SQL yourself; only the system can, and only against tables you have permission on).
- The rows the query returned become part of the answer.

A quality "Show SQL" panel is usually available — click it to see the exact query used. Compare it to the file if the number looks off.

Why this matters: an LLM asked to add up cells directly often makes small arithmetic errors, especially around decimal separators (, vs .). The SQL path avoids that entirely.

Typical table-math questions

- "Wie hoch ist die Summe der Kosten im Projekt Alpha?"
- "Welche Position hatte die längste Lieferfrist?"
- "Durchschnittliche Marge pro Quartal, 2024."
- "How many orders over €10 000 went to supplier X in Q2?"

Tip: mention the file name (.xlsx) whenever you can — it makes routing to the SQL path very reliable.

8. Following up in a conversation

The system remembers the current conversation. After:

"Welche Norm gilt für Typ-B-Schränke?"

you can say:

"Und welche Mindestanforderung an die Tiefe?"

and it will understand you're still on the same topic.

To reset: click **+ New** at the top left. That starts a fresh conversation with no memory. Do this whenever you change subject — it prevents the system from being biased by the previous topic.

Following up is especially powerful after a big answer:

- "Zeig mir nur Punkt 3."
- "Übersetze das ins Englische."
- "Woher stammt diese Zahl genau?"

9. Uploading documents

Not every user has upload rights. If you don't see **Upload** in the sidebar, your group isn't authorised. Ask your admin to grant access to a specific folder.

9.1 How to upload

1. Click **Upload** in the left sidebar.
2. Choose the **target folder** from the dropdown. Only folders your group is allowed to write to are listed — for example /qms/normen .

3. Drag files in. Supported formats: `.pdf` , `.docx` , `.doc` , `.xlsx` , `.xls` , plus `.pptx` , `.html` , and `.md` when the admin enables them.
4. Click **Ingest**.
5. The file appears under "In Progress" with a live status: `queued` → `parsing` → `embedding` → `indexed` .
6. Once **indexed**, the file is searchable. Typical timing:
 - Text PDF: ~10 seconds per page.
 - Scanned PDF (needs OCR): ~30 seconds per page.
 - Word / Excel: usually under a minute.

9.2 What happens to your file

- The **original** is stored unchanged in the system, versioned.
- A **parsed, chunked, searchable** copy is built for retrieval. The original is still what you see when you click a citation.
- **Nothing leaves the company.** There is no cloud call, no API upload, no telemetry.

9.3 Deleting a document

- Click the trash icon next to the file → confirm.
- By default this is a **soft delete**: the file is marked "superseded" and disappears from search, but the bytes are kept 30 days for audit recovery.
- A **hard delete** (permanent) is an admin-only action.

9.4 Replacing a document with a new version

Upload a file with the same name to the same folder. If the content has changed, a new version is created and the old one is marked `superseded` . The index uses the new version from that moment.

9.5 Don't upload secrets

The system logs query metadata for audit. It is designed for documents, not passwords or private keys. Use your password manager for those. Folder ACLs protect access, not secrecy of the document's internal content — if your XLSX contains a secret, someone authorised to read the folder can find it.

10. What you can and cannot see — permissions

Every document lives in a **folder** (a logical one, like `/qms/normen` or `/sales/angebote`). Each folder is configured with a list of **groups** allowed to read it.

Your view of the world

- You belong to one or more groups (typical ones: `engineering` , `sales` , `qms` , `finance` , `hr`).

- You can see a document only if **at least one** of your groups is on the folder's allow-list.
- Enforcement happens at retrieval time. If you ask about something in a folder you don't have access to, you get the "**information not available**" response — **no hint that such a document exists**. This is intentional — it avoids leaking the existence of sensitive files.

Your colleague's view may be different

Two colleagues can ask the same question and get different answers because they have different group memberships. That's working as designed, not a bug.

Asking for new access

If you believe you should have access to a folder and don't, ask your admin. ACL changes propagate within ~1 minute.

11. Privacy and what is logged

Transparency is part of the design. Here's exactly what is and isn't kept:

Logged (admin-visible audit trail)

- Your user id.
- Timestamp.
- The **query text** you typed.
- Which document ids the system retrieved for your query.
- Which language model answered.
- Response latency and token counts.
- A hash of the answer (for tamper-detection, not the answer text itself).

Not logged (by default)

- Your conversation history beyond the metadata above is **private to your account** in the UI.
- Administrators can view audit metadata but not your chat transcript unless your organisation has chosen a different policy — check with your admin or your data protection officer.

Retention

- Audit log: per company policy, typically **180 days**.
- Chat history in your account: as long as you don't delete it.
- Original documents: indefinitely, subject to your organisation's records policy.

Your GDPR / BDSG rights

You can request:

- A copy of your audit records.

- Deletion of your audit records (subject to any legal retention duty).
- A list of conversations on your account.

Direct these to your **data protection officer**.

The offline guarantee

No outbound network calls are made at runtime. The system was tested with the network cable unplugged; it degraded gracefully without calling anything external. Your queries, your uploads, your answers — **all stay inside the company**.

12. When something goes wrong

Symptom	Probable reason	Try this	
"I can't find a document I know exists."	Your group is not on the folder's allow-list.	Ask admin.	
"Answer is wrong, but cited."	The retrieved chunk looked related but isn't; or the document itself is inconsistent.	Rephrase; name the file or section; if it repeats, report it.	
"The answer has no citations."	Rare — the model omitted them.	Ask the same question again. If still none, report it.	
"It answered in the wrong language."	Model language detection.	Add "Answer in English." / "Antworte auf Deutsch." or toggle DE	EN.
"A table number seems wrong."	The SQL path may have picked the wrong column.	Expand "Show SQL", check the column names. Report mismatches.	
"It's taking forever."	A synthesis question can take up to a minute on large corpora.	Watch the streaming — it starts before it finishes. Or split the question.	
"I uploaded a file, nothing happened."	Queue busy or parser error.	Look at the status; if "failed", hover the info icon for the reason; contact admin.	
"I log in and see no documents."	Your account may not have any groups yet.	Ask admin to add you to the right group.	

How to report usefully to the admin

Include:

1. A **link to the conversation** (copy the URL from your browser bar).
2. The **exact question** you asked.
3. The **expected** answer vs. what you got.
4. If possible, **click a citation** and note whether the preview supports or contradicts the claim.

Your admin has tools (Langfuse, audit log) that can reconstruct the query end-to-end from the conversation URL and a timestamp.

13. Frequently asked questions

Q: Can I use Reineke-RAG to write a reply to a customer? Yes — it's a useful drafting tool. But **you** are responsible for what you send. Double-check the facts and citations before any outbound communication.

Q: Can it read a file I attach in the chat? No. Files enter the system only through the official **Upload** flow, which enforces folder permissions. Chat-attached files would bypass that — intentionally not supported.

Q: Why did it refuse to answer my question? Because nothing in the documents you can access supports an answer. This is deliberate — the system prefers "I don't know" to making something up.

Q: Why does my colleague's answer differ from mine on the same question? Different group memberships → different documents accessible → different citations → sometimes different answers. Working as designed.

Q: Does it learn from my corrections? Not automatically. Retrieval does not adapt from past queries by default (privacy choice). Admins can tune prompts and reranker weights based on audit trends; improvements appear quietly.

Q: What languages does it speak? German and English are fully supported and evaluated. Other languages may work (the embedding model covers 100+), but aren't formally tested.

Q: Can it translate? Yes. *"Translate §2.1 of Prozesshandbuch.pdf to English."* It will cite the source and translate. For legal-grade translation, still use a human translator.

Q: Can it summarise a whole folder? Yes, within reason: *"Summarise the key points from all documents under /qms/."* Very broad queries are less precise — narrower prompts are always better.

Q: Is there a size limit on files I can upload? Practically yes — very large scanned PDFs take longer to OCR. Ask your admin if you're unsure.

Q: Can I export a chat? Copy and paste works. Formal export is not in v1.

Q: Is my data safe? Everything runs on company hardware. No cloud. Communications are encrypted (HTTPS) between your browser and the server. Access is governed by your SSO account and group memberships.

14. A short exercise — your first good question

Try this to calibrate:

1. Pick a **specific document you remember** — say `Angebot-2024-09.pdf` .
2. Ask: *"Liste alle Lieferfristen aus Angebot-2024-09.pdf."*
3. Read the answer. Click **[1]**. Does the preview match?
4. Follow up: *"Für welche Position ist die Frist am kürzesten und warum?"*

5. Open the citation for the "why" — is the reason actually in the document?

If steps 3 and 5 both validate, you have the skill. The rest is practice.

15. Glossary

- **Chunk** — a small slice of a document (½ to 1 page) that the system uses internally for search. You never see chunks directly; they're the unit behind a citation.
 - **Citation** — the [1] , [2] bracketed references in the answer. Click to open the source.
 - **Folder** — a logical category like /qms/normen . Determines who can read which documents.
 - **Group** — a label (like engineering or qms) attached to your account by the admin. Used to decide what you can see.
 - **Hybrid retrieval** — the system uses both semantic search and keyword search at the same time. That's why KR-4711-B and "Schraubverbindung" both work.
 - **OCR** — Optical Character Recognition. Turns scanned images of text back into readable text so the system can search inside scanned PDFs.
 - **Refusal** — when the system says "I didn't find information on that..." . It's a deliberate behaviour, not an error.
 - **SQL path** — for numeric questions, the system writes and runs a small database query behind the scenes instead of asking the language model to do math.
 - **SSO** — Single Sign-On. One company login for everything.
 - **System prompt** — invisible instructions that tell the model to cite everything and never fabricate. You don't see it, but it shapes every answer.
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16. Getting help

- **Admin contact:** usually listed in the ⓘ **About** panel inside the UI; your admin fills this in during setup.
 - **Status page:** a Grafana dashboard at `https://rag.<company>.local/grafana/d/overview` shows whether the system is healthy. Usually admins watch this; end users can peek.
 - **Bug or feature request:** use your company's normal ticket system. Include the **URL of the offending conversation** — it makes triage much faster.
 - **Data protection questions:** your **data protection officer**, not the IT admin.
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Welcome to Reineke-RAG. Ask good questions, check the citations, and treat a refusal as information — not a failure.

Related documents:

- [TECH_DESCRIPTION.md](#) — what Reineke-RAG is, technically
- [TECHNICAL_HANDBOOK.md](#) — for administrators
- [docs/03_HANDBOOK.md](#) — the bundled end-user handbook (authoritative source for UI strings)